

W2 Trade-offs & Constraints

WHAT THIS FRAME MEANS

Most policy decisions involve giving something up to gain something else. This frame asks you to think about what is gained, what is lost, and what limits make the ideal solution unavailable. The goal is not to pick a side — it is to show that you understand the real costs on both sides.

WHAT TO TRY

- Name a clear benefit of the policy
- Name a real cost or limitation
- Explain why a perfect solution is not available — what constraint makes the trade-off necessary

SENTENCE STARTERS

- "The benefit of this approach is..., but the cost is..."
- "This policy would improve..., at the expense of..."
- "The challenge is that you cannot have both... and... simultaneously."
- "Even if the goal is worthwhile, the constraint is..."

EXAMPLE IN ACTION

"Requiring gig workers to receive full benefits would give them financial security, but it would also raise costs for platforms that currently operate on thin margins. The constraint is that benefit costs are fixed — companies cannot easily absorb them without raising prices or reducing the number of available gigs. There is a real trade-off between worker protection and job availability."